

FEDAGILE 2026 · RICHMOND

EXITING THE HERO TRAP

Shifting from Technical Expert to Post-Heroic Leader

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Raise your hand if you were promoted into leadership primarily because you were excellent at your technical or functional job.



Keep it up if someone trained you how to lead people before you needed to.



The Curse of the Silicon Valley is that great engineers are often promoted to leadership for their hard work. While many succeed in this role, an equal part fails because the skills required to lead are vastly different than the ones required to be an engineer. The Curse is that we're often placing our most valuable engineers in a role where they're predisposed to fail.

— Michael Lopp ("Rands"), *Being Geek: The Software Developer's Career Handbook*

Exiting the Hero Trap



The Problem

Naming the Hero Trap



The Inner Work

From Heroic to Post-Heroic



The Practices

What Helps the Shift

22%

global manager engagement, 2025 — down
from 31% in 2022

Gallup, State of the Global Workplace 2026

12%

of workers say AI has meaningfully changed how
work gets done

Microsoft, 2026 Work Trend Index (with Harvard Business School)

“This used to just cost you engagement. Now it’s costing you your AI ROI too.”



PART 1

Naming the Hero Trap

0:04 – 0:13 (9 min)



Heroic Leadership, Defined

“Years of experience have left most people with a deeply rooted belief that the main difference between managers and those who report to them is that the manager is responsible for the group’s success... That’s the mind-set of heroic leadership.”

— Bradford & Cohen, *Power Up: Transforming Organizations Through Shared Leadership* (1998)

Sole responsibility for setting objectives, coordinating the team, managing performance — you are the answer key.

Why It Worked. Why It's Breaking.



Complexity

Heroic leadership worked in stable environments with known problems and known solutions. Today's complexity outpaces what any one person's expertise can hold.



-42%

Middle-management postings since April 2022, as AI compresses the traditional slow-climb ladder

Revelio Labs workforce data, as reported in Forbes (Nov 2025)

The reflexive pull to be the one who solves it — the exact instinct that got you promoted — is now the thing standing in your way.

The Defects of Heroic Leadership

Bradford & Cohen, "Power Up", pp. 40–41

1

The leader shares too little information

2

Collective problem solving is discouraged

3

The leader is the only one taking the larger-unit perspective

4

The org has only one "sensing unit" — everyone else's situational awareness atrophies

5

Over-focus on control inhibits initiative from below

ACTIVITY · INDIVIDUAL + PAIR · 5 MIN



The Cost of Being the Hero

Think of a real moment in the last month where you were the hero — you jumped in and solved it yourself.

What did you do? What did it cost your team — a decision they didn't get to make, a skill they didn't get to build?

Write silently (90 sec) → pair share (90 sec each way) → optional room share (1–2 volunteers).

REMOTE: Same silent write. For the pair-share step, drop your answer in chat instead — I'll read a couple aloud alongside the room's volunteers.



PART 2

The Inner Work — From Heroic to Post-Heroic

0:13 – 0:29 (16 min)

Five Stages of Leadership Agility

William Joiner & Stephen Josephs, "*Leadership Agility*"



(plus Pre-Expert below Expert, and Co-Creator / Synergist beyond Catalyst — further down the road, not today's focus)

~90% of managers operate heroically (Pre-Expert / Expert / Achiever) →

~10% reach post-heroic (Catalyst and beyond)

This is the same heroic / post-heroic language Bradford & Cohen coined in *Power Up* (1998) — Joiner builds directly on it.

Two Ways to Answer “What's My Job?”

HEROIC LEADER

“It's my responsibility to determine the direction, to find the right answers, and to carry out the traditional management functions. It's your job to deliver in your area.”

POST-HEROIC LEADER

“Everyone is a leader. My job is to build a strong team with a common vision and mutual influence...”

— Bradford & Cohen, Power Up (1998), p. 49

Why the Hero Identity Is Hard to Give Up

“There is great satisfaction in saving the day when the rest of the team is floundering. There's more glory in being the quarterback [than the coach]...”

— Bradford & Cohen, *Power Up*, “The Seduction of Heroism,” pp. 67–68

“I will be less if I do this. I will have failed if I don't achieve. I should have known. They will finally know I am a fraud.”

— Michael Lopp (“Rands”), “The Slide” (2026)

ACTIVITY A · SMALL GROUPS OF 3–4 · 5 MIN



Expert vs. Catalyst

Your team just missed a critical deliverable the week before a stakeholder demo. What do you do in the next hour?

Split the table in half: one half scripts the Expert response, the other half scripts the Catalyst response. 3 min to write, then 2–3 tables read both versions aloud, back to back.

Debrief: In the Expert version — what did the team not get to do that they got to do in the Catalyst version?

REMOTE: Type your Expert-line / Catalyst-line in chat during the 3-min write — moderator will surface a couple for the debrief.

ACTIVITY B · INDIVIDUAL, SILENT, PRIVATE · 4 MIN



Your Own Slide Moment

(1) One leadership behavior you know you should change. (2) What are you afraid would happen if you did? (3) Finish the sentence: "If I stopped doing this, people would know I ____."

This is not going to be shared. If time is short, this flexes to a take-away — finish it on your own time today.

REMOTE: Works exactly the same for you — keep it on paper or in a private note, not chat.



PART 3

Supporting Practices — What Helps the Shift

0:29 – 0:39 (10 min)

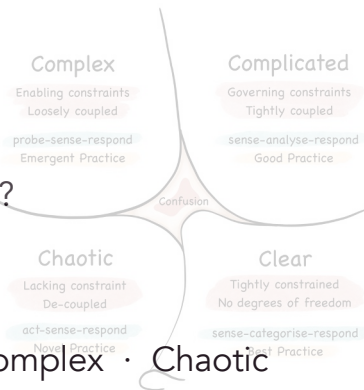
Two Passes Before You Act



Cynefin

What kind of system is this?

Clear · Complicated · Complex · Chaotic



Heifetz

What kind of challenge is this — and whose work is it?

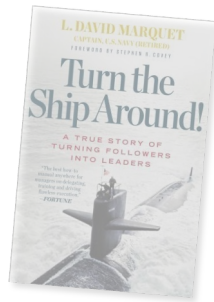
Technical (apply your expertise) vs.
Adaptive (the people with the problem must change)

Two lenses, one discipline: sensemaking before action — before the hero reflex triggers.

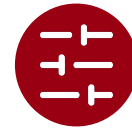
Handing Work Back, On Purpose



“I intend to...”



Marquet's language shift: turns a request for permission into a stated intention you approve.



Seven Levels of Delegation



Tell → Sell → Consult → Agree → Advise → Inquire → Delegate

Appelo's model: a dial you set per activity, not a single global setting.

ACTIVITY · SMALL GROUPS · 6 MIN



Sort It, Then Delegate It

Sort 4–5 scenario cards into a quick 2×2: domain (known / not-known) × ownership (mine to solve / theirs to solve).

For one card the group picks: draft the actual “I intend to...” sentence a team member should say, and pick which of the seven delegation levels fits.

Quick verbal share from 2 groups.

REMOTE: Type your 2×2 placement and “I intend to...” sentence in chat — moderator will flag one or two for the share-out.

CLOSE

0:39 – 0:42



Raise your hand again if you're still 100% sure the hero move is the safe move.

REMOTE: same poll link, re-opened

The shift isn't about doing less.

It's about doing the right thing before you act — and building the conditions for others to solve it.



On an index card, write one specific thing you'll delegate this week — using the “I intend to...” language we just practiced.

Collect or have them keep it — either works; collecting adds accountability if you want it.

REMOTE: type it in chat, or your own note — same commitment, no card needed.



Questions?

0:42 – 0:50

REFERENCES

Sources & Materials

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Get the materials: slides, source-document archive & activity handouts — [LINK TO BE ADDED]. Posted in chat for remote attendees at session start.